

Alert 8817 – Phishing Email and an Allowed Connection to a Malicious Login Page

Investigating a phishing email that led to a successful, allowed connection to confirmed malicious infrastructure.

Investigation at a glance	
Alert ID	8817
Alert rule	Inbound Email Containing Suspicious External Link
Severity	Medium (as raised)
Date	23 June 2026
Environment	TryHackMe SOC Simulator (Analyst VM)
Tools used	Splunk, TryDetectThis
Verdict	True Positive — escalated to Level 2 (possible account compromise)

Goal / Objective

A Medium severity phishing alert (8817) came in for an inbound email that contained a suspicious external link. The alert asked me to check the firewall and proxy logs to see whether any endpoint had actually tried to reach the link, and whether that connection was allowed or blocked. My job was to triage the alert, confirm whether the email was a real phishing attempt, find out if the user clicked and what the firewall did about it, decide whether it could be closed at Level 1 or needed escalating, and write a clear case report for whoever picked it up next.

Tools Used

- Splunk — the SIEM I used to search the email and firewall logs.
- TryDetectThis — a URL and IP reputation tool, used to confirm the domain, the URL, and the server IP.
- TryHackMe SOC Simulator (Analyst VM) — the simulated SOC environment, including the alert queue and case report system.
- Email logs — used to read the phishing message and find the link inside it.
- Firewall logs — web-browsing traffic, used to see whether the connection was allowed or blocked.

What I Did

1. Picked up Alert 8817 and read the email details — a Microsoft “unusual sign-in” message with a link, sent to c.allen.

2. Searched the recipient in Splunk to pull the email and confirm what it contained.
3. Identified the phishing signs: a lookalike sender domain, a fake login link, and fear-based urgency.
4. Searched the source host (10.20.2.25) to see whether the machine connected to the link, and whether the firewall allowed or blocked it.
5. Searched the malicious domain directly to confirm the connection and tie it back to the email.
6. Ran the domain, the full URL, and the server IP through TryDetectThis to confirm the reputation.
7. Classified the alert as a True Positive and wrote the case report, treating it as a possible account compromise.
8. Marked the alert for escalation to Level 2 and submitted it.

Investigation Summary

I picked up Alert 8817 from the queue. It was a Medium severity phishing alert called “Inbound Email Containing Suspicious External Link,” raised on 23 June 2026 at around 06:11. The email was a Microsoft “unusual sign-in” message sent to c.allen@thetrydaily.thm from no-reply@microsoftsupport.co. It claimed someone had signed into the user’s Microsoft account from Lagos and pushed them to “Review Activity” through a link. The alert told me to check the firewall or proxy logs to see whether any endpoint had tried to reach the link, and whether that connection was allowed or blocked — so that became the main question to answer.

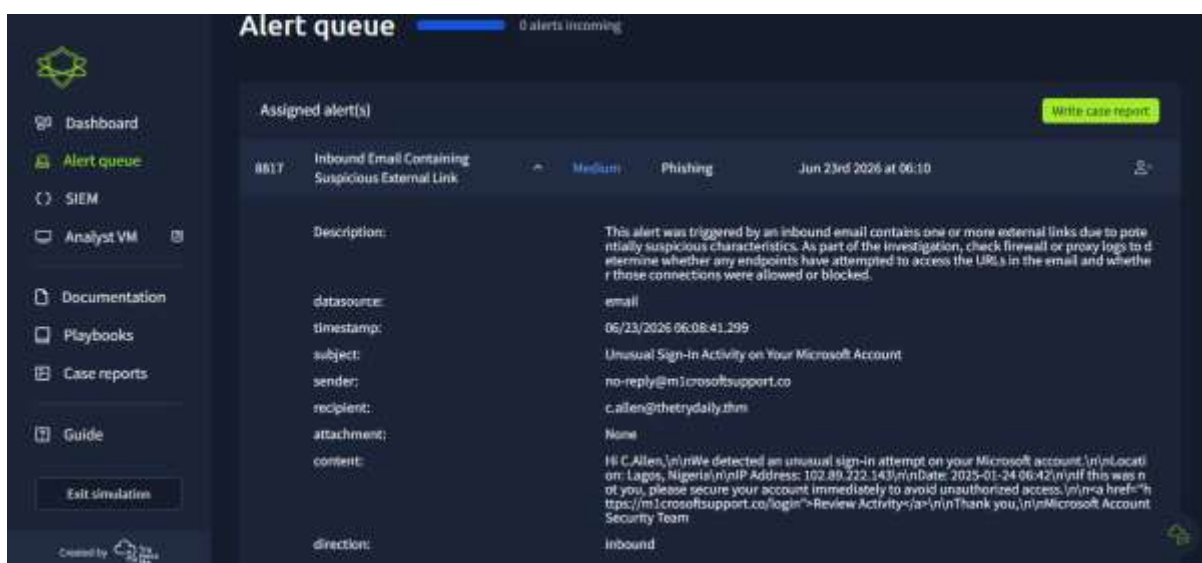


Figure 1 — Alert 8817 in the queue. A Medium severity phishing alert: an inbound email to c.allen containing a suspicious external link.

Finding the email

I started by searching the recipient, c.allen@thetrydaily.thm, in Splunk to pull the email itself.

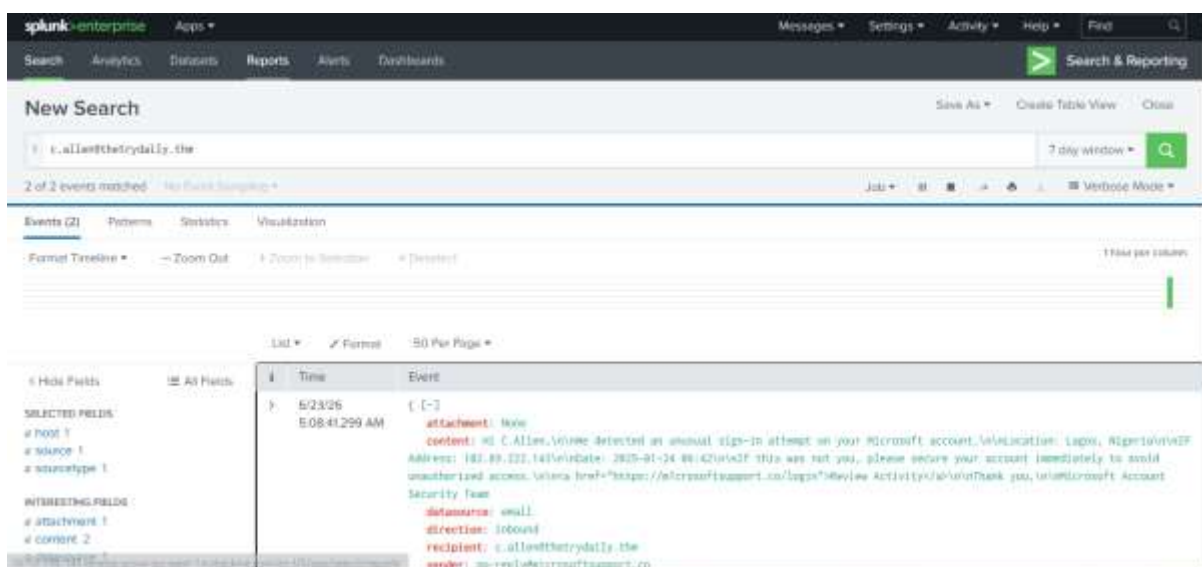


Figure 2 — Searching the recipient (c.allen@thetrydaily.thm) in Splunk. Two inbound emails were returned.

Two inbound emails came back. The first was the phishing message — the Microsoft sign-in lure from no-reply@microsoftsupport.co. The second was a separate, ordinary business email: a networking luncheon invitation from a different sender, which read as normal and wasn't related. So only one of the two was a threat.



Figure 3 — The two emails: the Microsoft sign-in phish from m1crosoftsupport.co, and a separate, normal networking invitation.

The phishing email had the usual tells. The sender domain, m1crosoftsupport.co, is a lookalike of microsoft.com — it uses the number 1 in place of the “i”, and it ends in .co rather than .com. The link in the email pointed to <https://m1crosoftsupport.co/login>, a fake Microsoft sign-in page built to capture whatever the user typed. The message leaned on fear and urgency (“secure your account immediately to avoid unauthorized access”) to push a fast click, and the real link was hidden behind the words “Review Activity.” One detail worth noting: the email also showed

an IP address (102.89.222.143) as the supposed sign-in location. That IP is part of the scare story, not the attacker's infrastructure, so I left it out of the investigation and focused on the domain in the link.

Checking what the host actually did

Next I searched the source host, 10.20.2.25 (Charlotte Allen's machine, win-3463), to see what it had actually done. Seven events came back for that host.

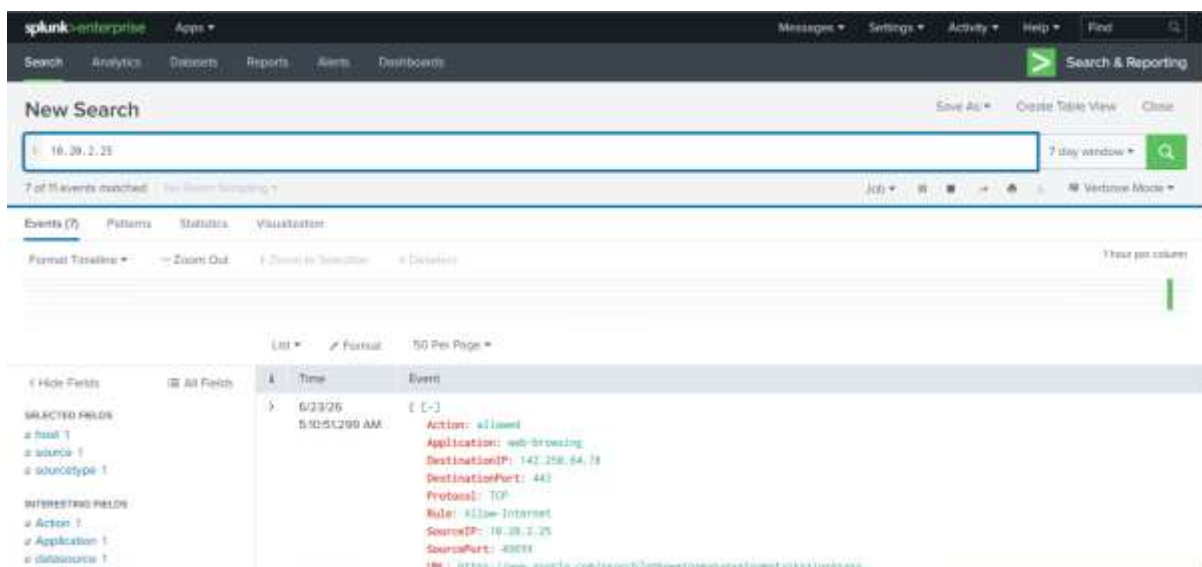


Figure 4 — Searching the source host (10.20.2.25) in Splunk to see what the machine did. Seven events were returned.

The important one was at 06:09:50: the host connected to <https://m1crosoftsupport.co/login>, and the firewall allowed the connection under the “Allow-Internet” rule. This is the part that makes 8817 serious. The malicious domain wasn’t on the company blacklist, so instead of being blocked it was simply waved through as ordinary web traffic. The email had arrived at 06:08:41, so the click came about 69 seconds later — the user opened the email and clicked almost straight away.

Hide Fields All Fields List Format 50 Per Page	<table border="1"> <thead> <tr> <th>Time</th><th>Event</th></tr> </thead> <tbody> <tr> <td>6/23/26 6:09:50.299 AM</td><td> <pre>[{"Action": "allowed", "Application": "web-browsing", "DestinationIP": "45.148.18.131", "DestinationPort": 443, "Protocol": "TCP", "Rule": "Allow-Internet", "SourceIP": "10.30.2.25", "SourcePort": 52531, "URL": "https://m1crosoftsupport.co/login", "datasource": "firewall", "timestamp": "06/23/2016 06:09:50.299"}]</pre> Show as raw text host = 10.30.2.25 source = eventcollector sourcetype = _json </td></tr> <tr> <td>6/23/26 6:09:24.299 AM</td><td> <pre>[{"Action": "allowed", "Application": "web-browsing", "DestinationIP": "172.16.45.4", "DestinationPort": 443, "Protocol": "TCP", "Rule": "Allow-Internet", "SourceIP": "10.30.2.25", "SourcePort": 52547, "URL": "https://admin.thetrydaily.th/orders/overview", "datasource": "firewall"}]</pre> Show as raw text host = 10.30.2.25 source = eventcollector sourcetype = _json </td></tr> </tbody> </table>	Time	Event	6/23/26 6:09:50.299 AM	<pre>[{"Action": "allowed", "Application": "web-browsing", "DestinationIP": "45.148.18.131", "DestinationPort": 443, "Protocol": "TCP", "Rule": "Allow-Internet", "SourceIP": "10.30.2.25", "SourcePort": 52531, "URL": "https://m1crosoftsupport.co/login", "datasource": "firewall", "timestamp": "06/23/2016 06:09:50.299"}]</pre> Show as raw text host = 10.30.2.25 source = eventcollector sourcetype = _json	6/23/26 6:09:24.299 AM	<pre>[{"Action": "allowed", "Application": "web-browsing", "DestinationIP": "172.16.45.4", "DestinationPort": 443, "Protocol": "TCP", "Rule": "Allow-Internet", "SourceIP": "10.30.2.25", "SourcePort": 52547, "URL": "https://admin.thetrydaily.th/orders/overview", "datasource": "firewall"}]</pre> Show as raw text host = 10.30.2.25 source = eventcollector sourcetype = _json
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Figure 5 — The key event: at 06:09:50 the host connected to <https://m1crosoftsupport.co/login> and the firewall ALLOWED it under the 'Allow-Internet' rule.

The rest of the host's activity was routine work. There were connections to internal company sites, Facebook Ads Manager, Asana, and a Google search about competitor tools — all normal for someone in a web and marketing role.

Hide Fields All Fields List Format 50 Per Page	<table border="1"> <thead> <tr> <th>Time</th><th>Event</th></tr> </thead> <tbody> <tr> <td>6/23/26 6:09:03.299 AM</td><td> <pre>[{"URL": "https://admin.thetrydaily.th/orders/overview", "datasource": "firewall", "timestamp": "06/23/2016 06:09:03.299"}]</pre> Show as raw text host = 10.30.2.25 source = eventcollector sourcetype = _json </td></tr> <tr> <td>6/23/26 6:09:03.299 AM</td><td> <pre>[{"Action": "allowed", "Application": "web-browsing", "DestinationIP": "10.8.8.16", "DestinationPort": 443, "Protocol": "TCP", "Rule": "Allow-Internet", "SourceIP": "10.30.2.25", "SourcePort": 52557, "URL": "https://inventory.thetrydaily.th/readers", "datasource": "firewall", "timestamp": "06/23/2016 06:09:03.299"}]</pre> Show as raw text host = 10.30.2.25 source = eventcollector sourcetype = _json </td></tr> <tr> <td>6/23/26 6:08:40.299 AM</td><td> <pre>[{"Action": "allowed", "Application": "web-browsing", "DestinationIP": "157.140.25.35", "DestinationPort": 443, "Protocol": "TCP", "Rule": "Allow-Internet", "SourceIP": "10.30.2.25", "SourcePort": 52567, "URL": "https://www.facebook.com/adsmanager", "datasource": "firewall", "timestamp": "06/23/2016 06:08:40.299"}]</pre> Show as raw text host = 10.30.2.25 source = eventcollector sourcetype = _json </td></tr> </tbody> </table>	Time	Event	6/23/26 6:09:03.299 AM	<pre>[{"URL": "https://admin.thetrydaily.th/orders/overview", "datasource": "firewall", "timestamp": "06/23/2016 06:09:03.299"}]</pre> Show as raw text host = 10.30.2.25 source = eventcollector sourcetype = _json	6/23/26 6:09:03.299 AM	<pre>[{"Action": "allowed", "Application": "web-browsing", "DestinationIP": "10.8.8.16", "DestinationPort": 443, "Protocol": "TCP", "Rule": "Allow-Internet", "SourceIP": "10.30.2.25", "SourcePort": 52557, "URL": "https://inventory.thetrydaily.th/readers", "datasource": "firewall", "timestamp": "06/23/2016 06:09:03.299"}]</pre> Show as raw text host = 10.30.2.25 source = eventcollector sourcetype = _json	6/23/26 6:08:40.299 AM	<pre>[{"Action": "allowed", "Application": "web-browsing", "DestinationIP": "157.140.25.35", "DestinationPort": 443, "Protocol": "TCP", "Rule": "Allow-Internet", "SourceIP": "10.30.2.25", "SourcePort": 52567, "URL": "https://www.facebook.com/adsmanager", "datasource": "firewall", "timestamp": "06/23/2016 06:08:40.299"}]</pre> Show as raw text host = 10.30.2.25 source = eventcollector sourcetype = _json
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Figure 6 — The rest of the host's traffic was routine work: internal company sites and Facebook Ads Manager, all normal.

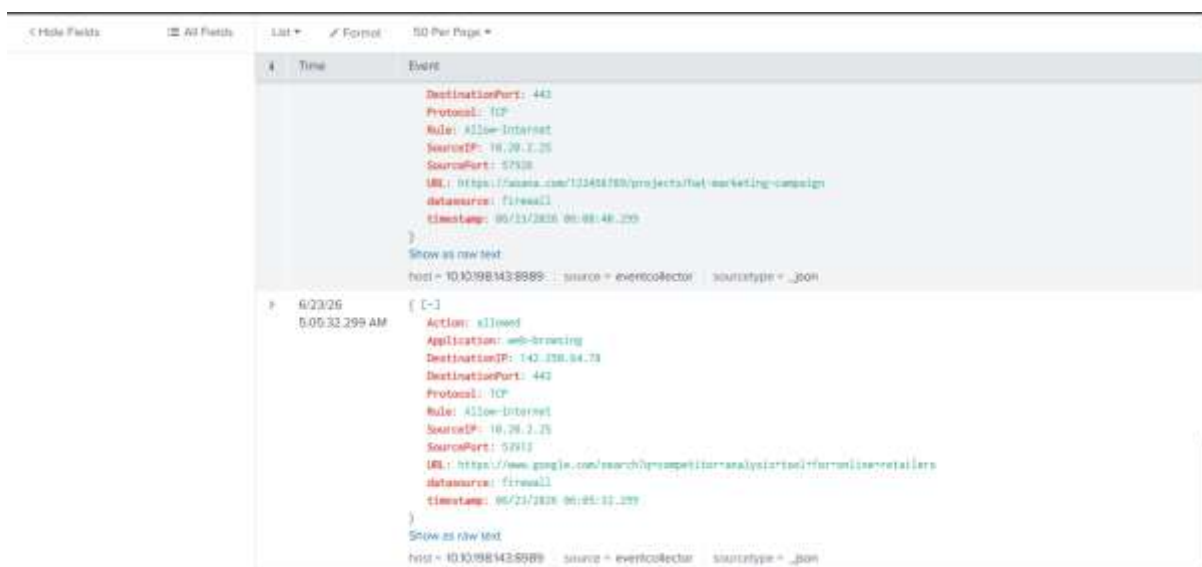


Figure 7 — More routine activity from the same host: Asana and a Google search about competitor tools. Only the m1crosoftsupport.co connection stood out.

Going through the full set mattered, because it confirmed the only dangerous connection in the host's traffic was the one to m1crosoftsupport.co. Everything else was benign.

Confirming through the domain

To tie it together, I searched the malicious domain directly, m1crosoftsupport.co.

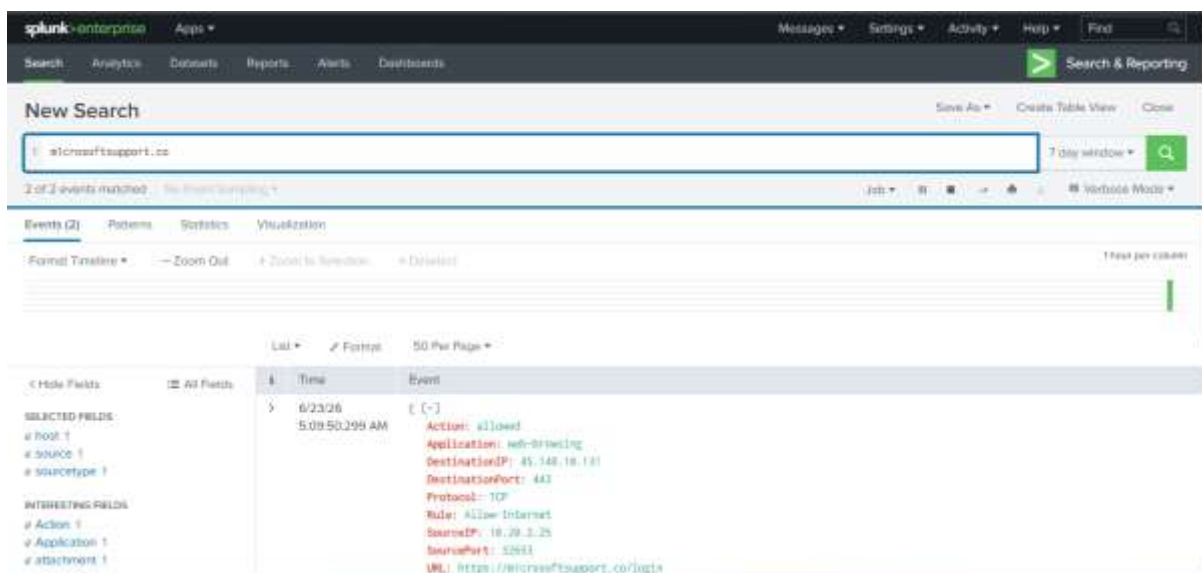


Figure 8 — Searching the malicious domain (m1crosoftsupport.co) directly. Two events were returned.

The results showed the same allowed connection from 10.20.2.25 to the /login page, alongside the original phishing email that delivered the link. That confirmed the chain from end to end: the email carried the link, and the host connected to it.

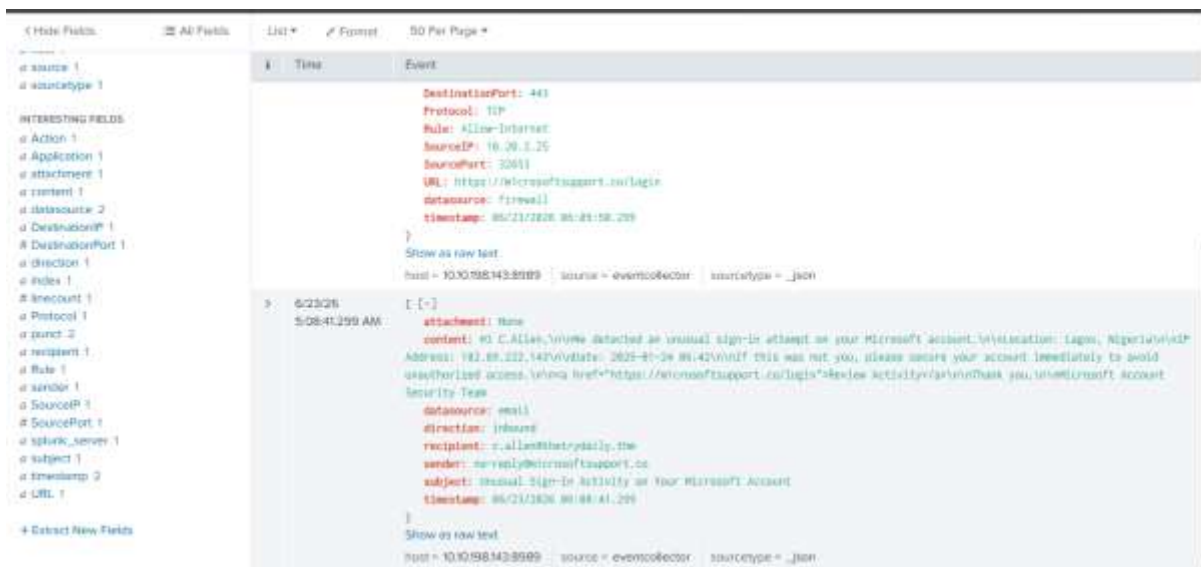


Figure 9 — The domain search confirms the allowed connection from 10.20.2.25, alongside the phishing email that delivered the link.

Confirming the reputation

I then confirmed the reputation of everything involved using TryDetectThis. I checked three things to be thorough — the domain, the exact URL, and the server IP the host actually connected to.

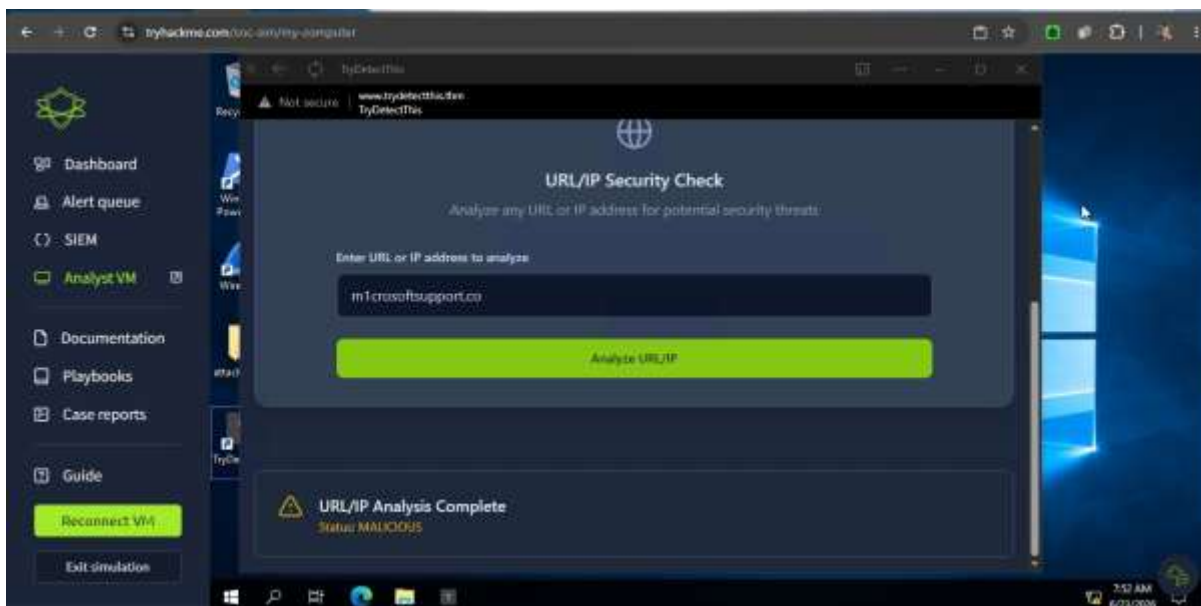


Figure 10 — TryDetectThis check on the domain m1crosoftsupport.co: status MALICIOUS.

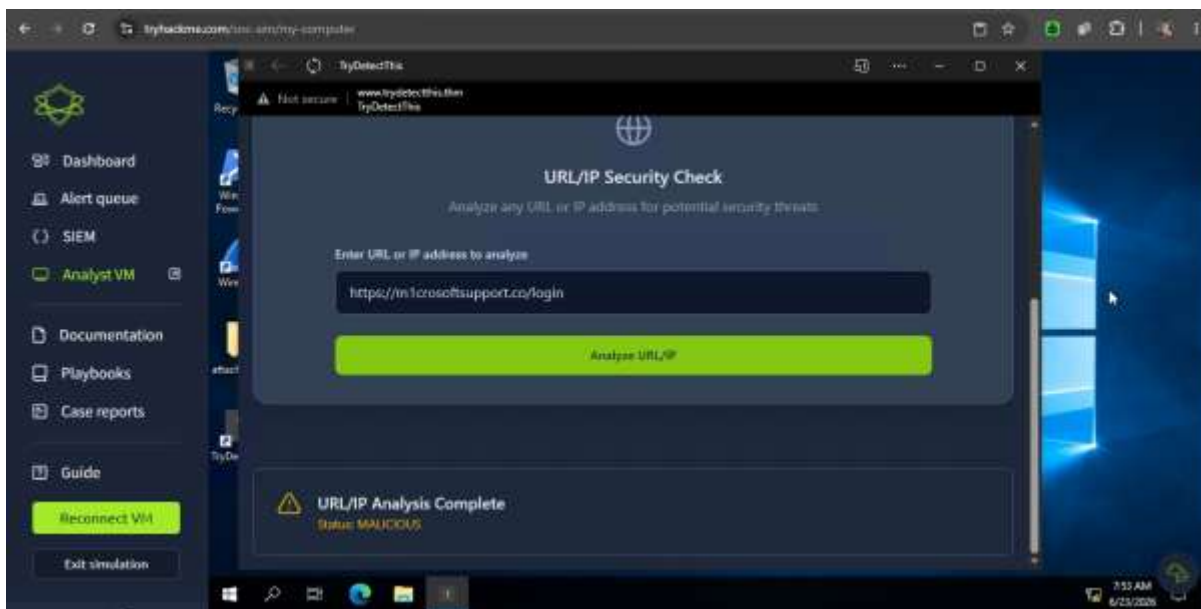


Figure 11 — TryDetectThis check on the full URL <https://m1crosoftsupport.co/login>: status MALICIOUS.

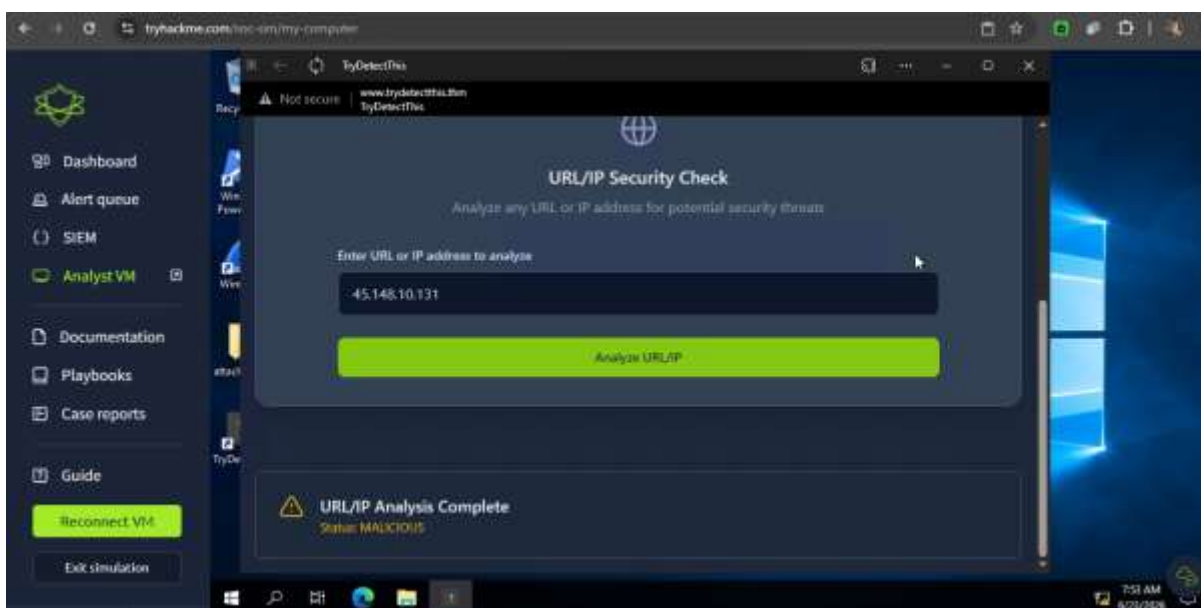


Figure 12 — TryDetectThis check on the server IP 45.148.10.131 (the address actually connected to): status MALICIOUS.

All three came back MALICIOUS. The third one matters most: 45.148.10.131 is the address Charlotte’s machine actually reached, and confirming it as malicious closes any gap in the evidence. It is a different IP from the 102.89.222.143 in the email body, which — as expected — was just the scare-story lure.

Documenting the case and making the call

With the analysis done, I wrote up the case report for event 8817.



Figure 13 — Starting the case report for event 8817.

I set the classification to True Positive, because a real phishing email had led to a successful connection to confirmed malicious infrastructure.

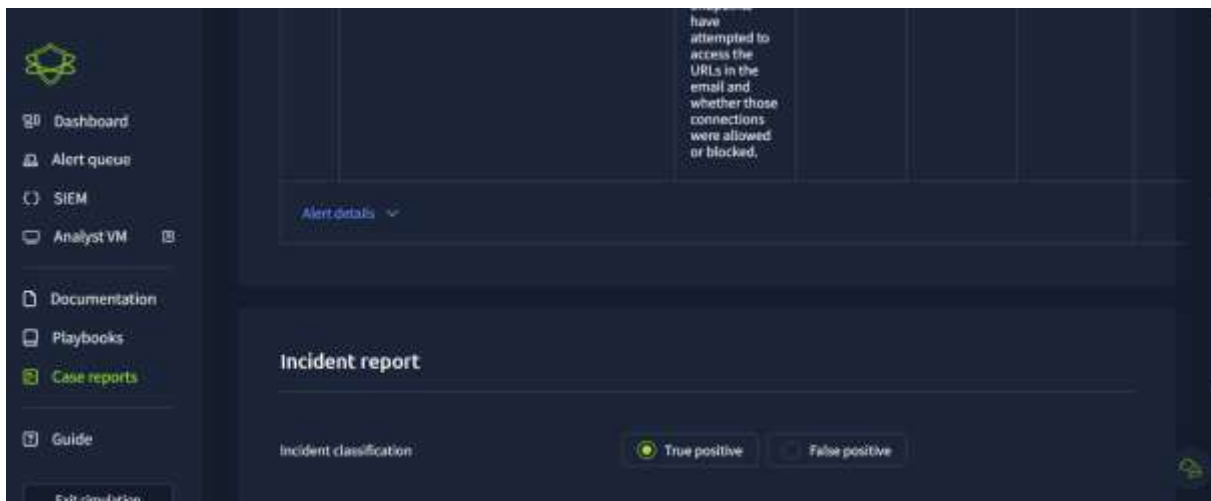


Figure 14 — Setting the incident classification to True Positive.

In the report I recorded the time of activity and the affected entities — Charlotte Allen, her host (win-3463 / 10.20.2.25), the malicious domain and URL, and the server IP.

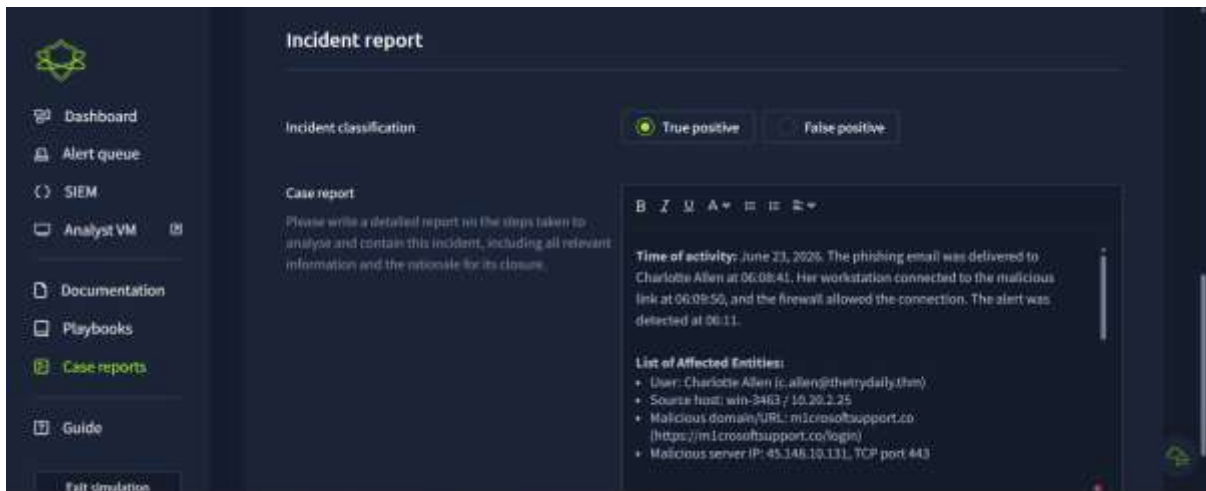


Figure 15 — The case report: time of activity and the list of affected entities.

I explained the True Positive reasoning, then why it needed escalating.

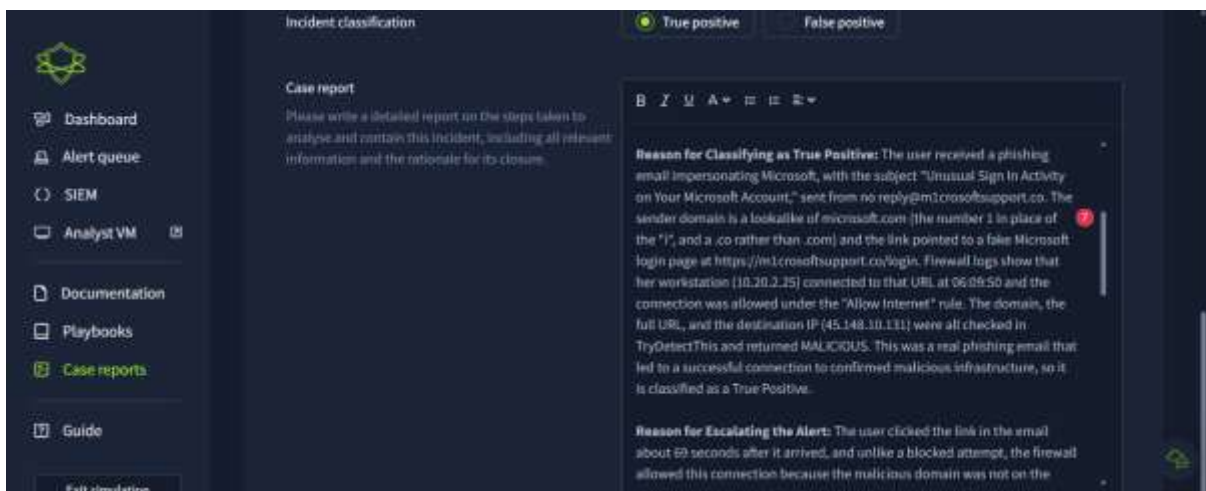


Figure 16 — The case report: reasoning for the True Positive verdict.

The key point for escalation is that this wasn't a blocked attempt like the earlier firewall alert — the connection was allowed, so the user's browser reached a credential-harvesting page. I was careful with the wording: the firewall logs prove the connection succeeded, but they can't show whether she actually typed in her password, so I treated it as a possible account compromise rather than a confirmed one.

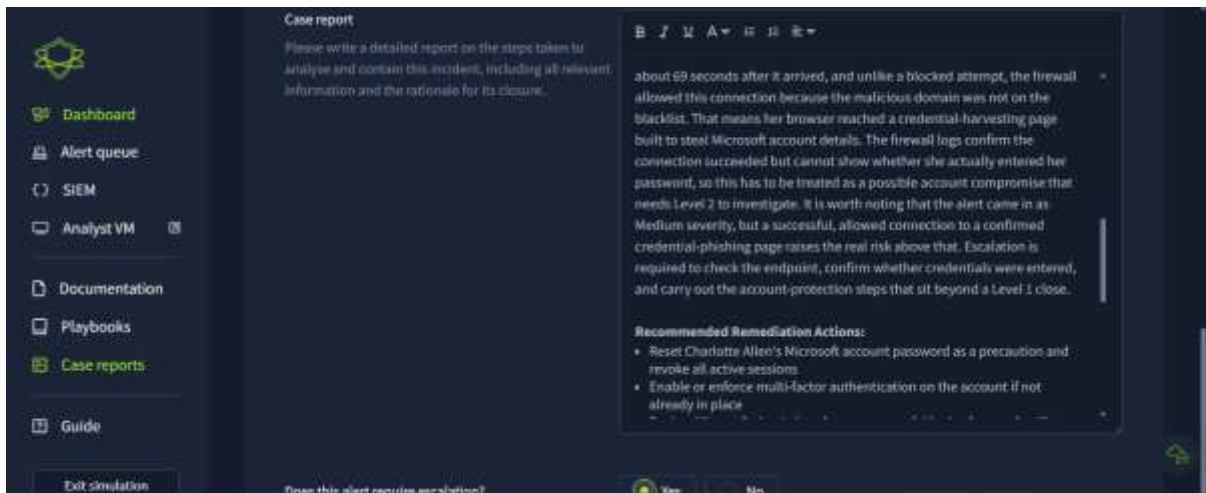


Figure 17 — The case report: escalation reasoning and the start of the remediation actions.

The remediation actions focused on protecting the account: reset the password and revoke sessions, enable MFA, review the Microsoft sign-in logs for any logins from unfamiliar locations, isolate and scan the host, block the domain and IP everywhere, add the indicators to the blacklist, search the mail environment for other recipients, and follow up with the user on phishing awareness.

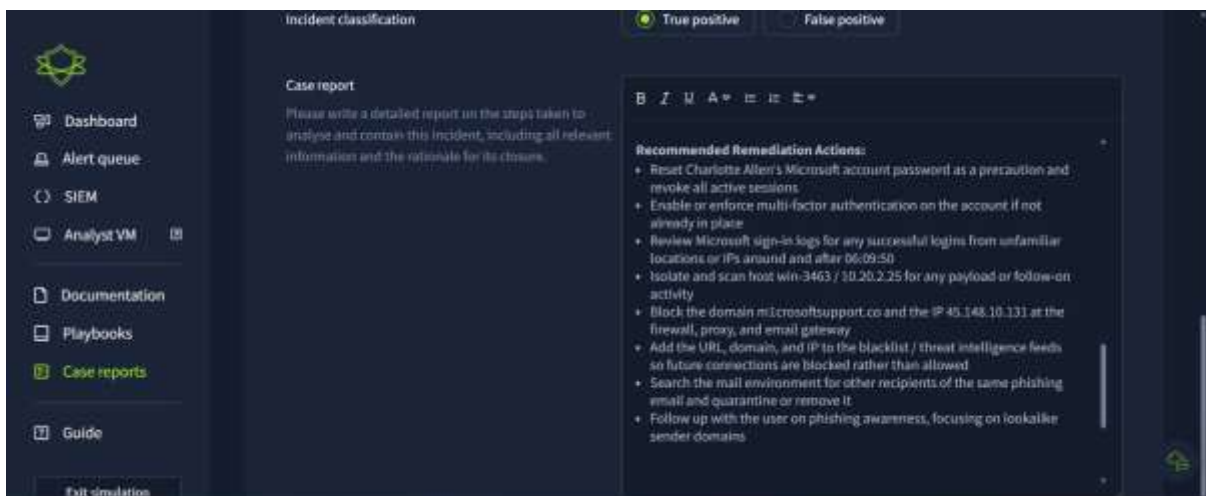


Figure 18 — The case report: the recommended remediation actions, focused on account protection.

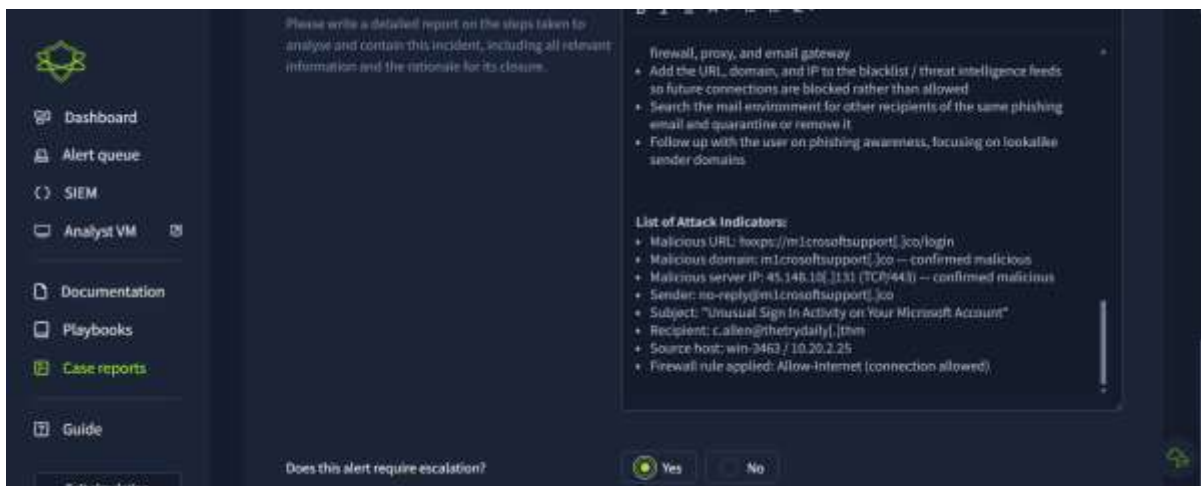


Figure 19 — The case report: remediation actions and the list of attack indicators.

Finally I added the list of attack indicators — the URL, domain, server IP, sender, subject, recipient, host, and the firewall rule that allowed it — set escalation to Yes, and submitted to close the alert.

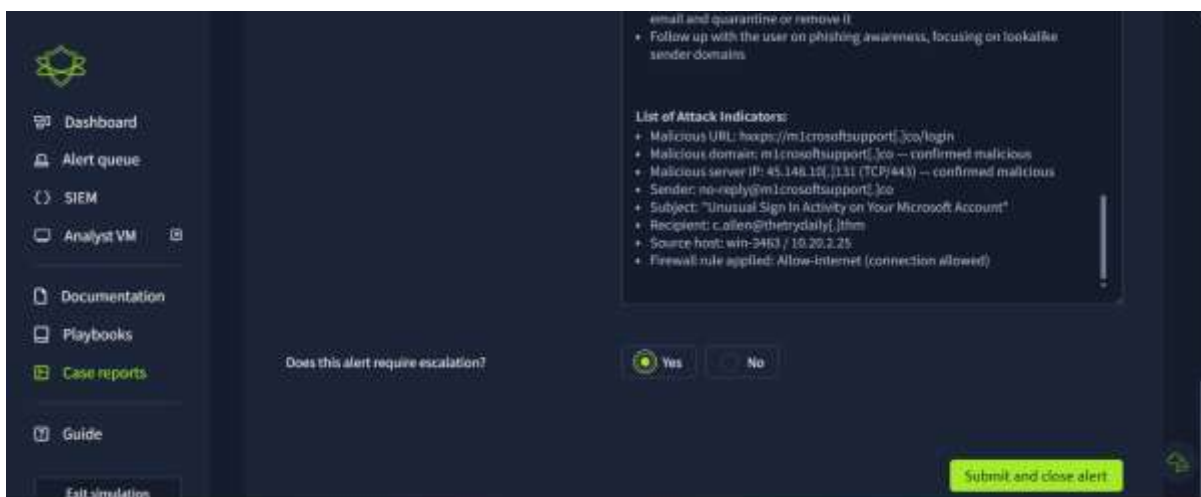


Figure 20 — The case report: attack indicators, escalation set to Yes, ready to submit and close.

One thing I flagged in the report: the alert came in as Medium severity, but a successful, allowed connection to a confirmed credential-phishing page realistically carries more risk than that. I noted that the severity felt understated given the connection went through, so whoever handles the escalation treats it with the right urgency.

Results / Findings

The investigation confirmed a real phishing attack that wasn't stopped. In short:

- Charlotte Allen received a phishing email impersonating Microsoft, designed to steal her account password.

- She clicked the link about 69 seconds after it arrived, and the firewall allowed the connection because the malicious domain wasn't on the blacklist.
- Her machine (10.20.2.25 / win-3463) reached the fake login page at <https://m1crosoftsupport.co/login>.
- TryDetectThis confirmed the domain, the URL, and the server IP (45.148.10.131) as malicious.
- The rest of the host's activity was routine and benign.
- I classified the alert as a True Positive and escalated it to Level 2 as a possible account compromise.

Key indicators (IOCs)	
Malicious URL	hxxps://m1crosoftsupport[.]co/login
Malicious domain	m1crosoftsupport[.]co — confirmed malicious
Malicious server IP	45.148.10[.]131 (TCP/443) — confirmed malicious
Phishing sender	no-reply@m1crosoftsupport[.]co
Email subject	Unusual Sign-In Activity on Your Microsoft Account
Affected user	c.allen@thetrydaily[.]thm
Source host	win-3463 / 10.20.2.25
Firewall rule applied	Allow-Internet (connection allowed)
Verdict	True Positive — escalated to Level 2

Indicators are defanged, which is standard practice in written reports so the links can't be clicked by accident. The 102.89.222.143 address from the email body is deliberately excluded — it was a decoy used in the lure, not real attacker infrastructure.

Skills Demonstrated

- Alert triage and prioritisation
- Phishing email analysis (lookalike domains, fake login pages, social engineering)
- SIEM log analysis with Splunk
- Pivoting across email and firewall logs
- Distinguishing allowed vs blocked connections in firewall data
- URL, domain, and IP reputation checks / threat intelligence
- Indicator of Compromise (IOC) identification
- Incident classification (true positive vs false positive)
- Escalation decision-making and recognising a possible account compromise
- Avoiding false leads (the decoy IP in the email body)
- Incident documentation and case report writing

What I Learned

The main lesson from this one was the difference between a blocked attempt and an allowed one. A firewall block means the threat was stopped; an allowed connection to a malicious page means the user may have reached it and handed over their details, which is a completely

different level of risk. Reading the “allowed” in the firewall log is what turned this from a delivered phishing email into a possible account compromise. I also learned to watch for decoy details — the IP address in the email body was there to look scary and would have come back clean if I’d checked it, so knowing to go after the domain in the link instead saved me from a wrong conclusion. Checking the domain, the URL, and the server IP separately gave me a complete, confirmed picture rather than a partial one. And writing the report reminded me to stay precise: say the connection succeeded, but don’t claim the password was stolen when the logs can’t show that. Overall it was good practice at judging real impact, not just spotting that an email was malicious.